

MANIKA BATRA BEAT HIGHER-RANKED PRITHIKA PAVADE 11-9, 11-6, 11-9, 11-7 TO REGISTER A HISTORIC WIN, WITH THE INDIAN'S BACKHAND BEING THE HIGHLIGHT OF THE MATCH

Trailblazer: Manika Batra became the first Indian table tennis player to reach the round of 16 in the Olympic Games singles competition after a 4-0 thrashing of higher-ranked Prithika Pavade of France. AFP

facing the top-seeded Chinese and Asian Games champion Wu Yu in the pre-quarterfinals.

Asian Games bronze medallist Preeti Pawar also had a strong start, winning 5-0 against Vietnam's Vo Thi Kim Anh to advance to the round of 16. Preeti's next match will be against World silver medallist Yeni Arias of Colombia.

Table Tennis

Harmeet Desai had a great start in the men's singles by defeating

Jordan's Zaid Abo Yaman 4-0, but unfortunately, he was eliminated in the round of 64 by France's Felix Lebrun, suffering a 4-0 loss. In a surprising turn of events, Sharath Kamal, India's flagbearer at the opening ceremony, was also knocked out in the round of 64 by Slovenia's Deni Kozul, with a 2-4 defeat.

In the women's singles, Manika Batra and Sreeja Akula performed exceptionally well. Manika defeated Great Britain's Anna Hursey 4-1, while Sreeja won 4-0 against Sweden's Christina Kallberg.

Manika then advanced to the round of 16 with a decisive 4-0 win over France's Prithika Pavade. This makes her the first Indian table tennis player to reach this stage at the Olympics.

Rowing

Balraj Panwar advanced to the men's single sculls quarterfinals with a strong performance in the repechage round. He finished second with a time of 7:12.41. In an earlier heat, he placed fourth, where only the top three automatically qualified for the quarterfinals. This left Panwar and others to compete in the repechage for another chance to advance.

Hockey

In an exciting match, Harmanpreet Singh scored a late goal to secure a vital point for the Indian men's hockey team, drawing 1-1 with Argentina in their second Pool B game. India started its campaign with a 3-2 win over New Zealand and currently holds the third